triumphant look.

Thereafter, Brigadier Airy held a conference of all his commanding officers and directed all of us to prepare for the exercise. After that he called me separately to his office and spoke to me in confidence. The sum and substance of our discussion was that my battalion would do the task of Redland, the attackers. The other battalion, 3 Garhwal Rifles, would act as Blueland, and defend its territory employing the tactics of mobile defence. Before I left his office, Brigadier Airy asked me, 'JJ, tell me frankly, what do you think of the proposed concept?'

'Considering our present organization, weapons and equipment state, particularly the radio communications, I do not think that the new concept would work in such a harsh and rugged mountainous terrain, sir,' was my unambiguous reply.

A smile lit up his rustic face as he took a puff from his cigarette, and shrugged the ash off in true Haryanvi style, with a twitch of his left hand.

'In that case,' he said, 'I would like to see your battalion tearing this silly idea to shreds. Do you get it, JJ?'

'We will do our best, you can be sure of that, sir', was my confident reply, as I looked into his eyes. He then took a final gulp of his tea with a typically rustic slurp, and lit another cigarette.

All the participants had been mulling over the mobile defence issue ever since the infamous sand model discussion. I had also discussed the matter with my officers to get their views, and the consensus was against the new concept.

The Division HQ had taken upon itself the task of close monitoring and supervision of the conduct of the exercise. The level of 'closeness' was unprecedented. For example, an umpire of the rank of brigadier was nominated to report on the activities and conduct of the commanding officer of an infantry battalion of the rank of lieutenant colonel! The general norm is to have an umpire of the same rank as that of the officer being exercised. And the two COs and their battalions were the guinea pigs under the scanner. However, the stakes being so high, such things were to be expected. The professional reputation of all the key players could be made or